



Posted Once, Believed Forever

A Survey of Renovation-Completion-Date Recall Against a Hoarding Sign's Own Logged Revisions

Verity Marris · Ingrid Vasseur — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

A renovation hoarding posts an expected completion date and keeps revising it as the works run over. Does belief in that date track the sign's latest repaint, or does whichever date first went up simply outlast every correction painted over it?

Research questions

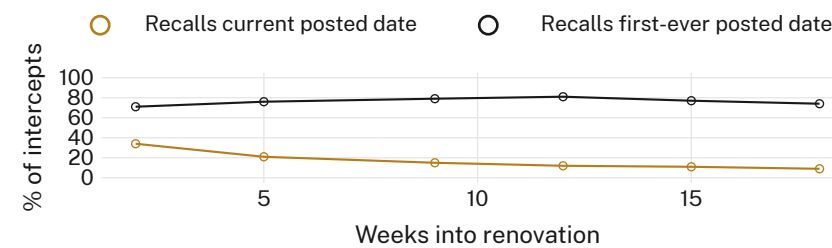
- Does recall of a renovation's posted completion date match the hoarding's most recent revision?
- Does belief instead anchor to the first date ever painted on the sign?
- Does recall accuracy track days elapsed since the sign's last repaint?

Study design

- $n = 182$ intercept surveys at a single hoarding fence · one open-recall question · 18-week renovation window
- weekly photographed revision log cross-referenced against each response's stated date
- mixed-effects logistic regression of recall type on repaint count; intercept location held constant throughout

Findings

Recall matches the sign's currently posted date in as few as 9% of later-window intercepts. Recall of the first date ever painted on the hoarding holds above 70% throughout, regardless of five subsequent repaintings ($n = 182$).



Recall of the hoarding sign's currently posted completion date fell from 34% in week 2 to 9% by week 18, while recall of the first date ever painted on the sign held above 70% throughout five intervening revisions ($n = 182$ intercepts, 2026).

Implications

Consistent with belief anchoring to a signage instrument's initial state rather than its maintained one: repainting changes the sign, not what passers-by report believing. The effect held regardless of how visually distinct each repaint was from the last.

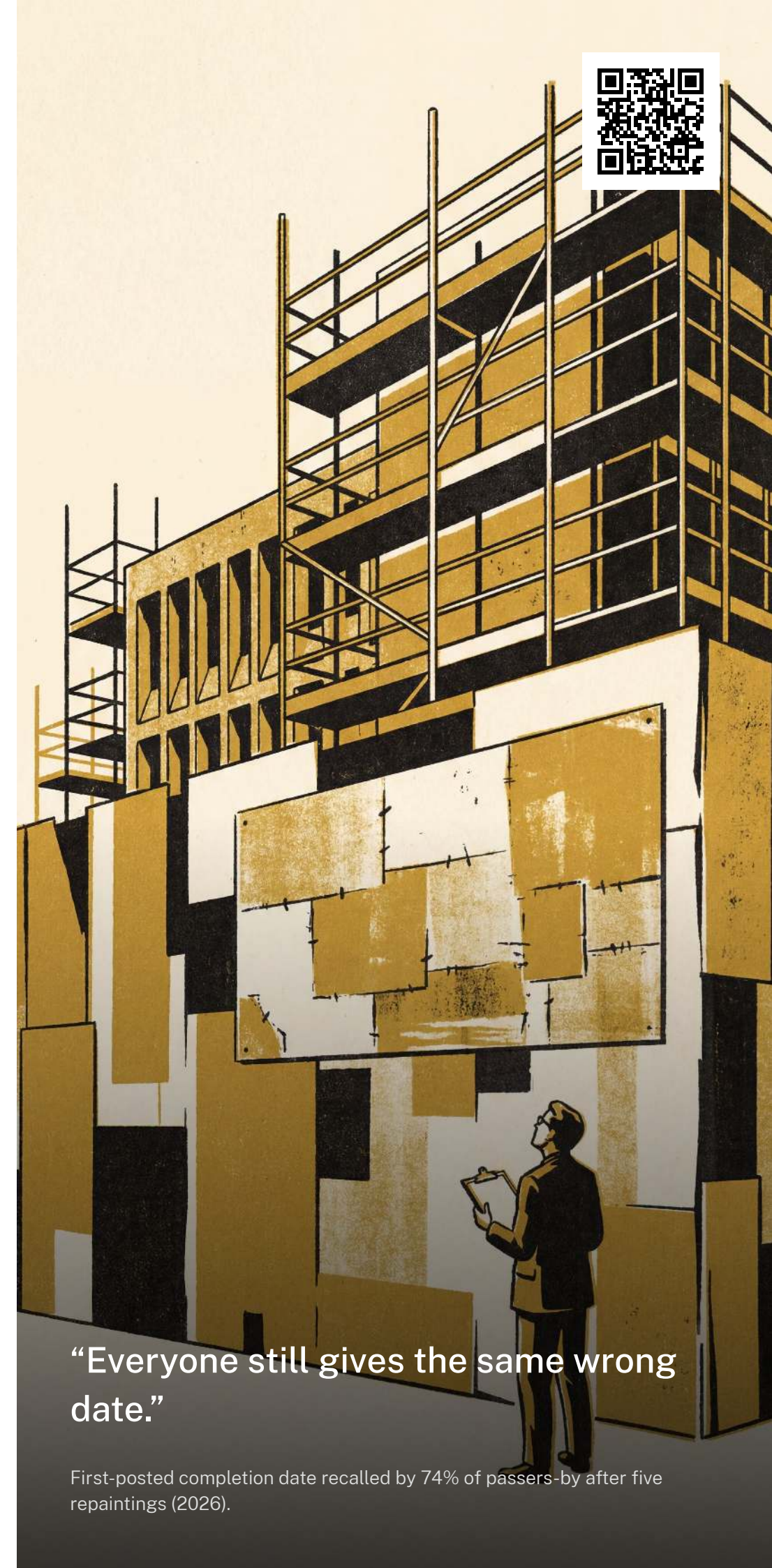
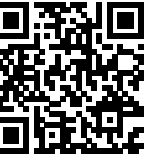
Next: testing whether relocating the notice to a second, physically separate board updates recall faster than revising it in place.

Selected references

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Intercepts anonymous and voluntary; no respondent identifying details recorded. Supported by a School of Emergent Priorities seed allocation; we thank Facilities for hoarding access.

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“Everyone still gives the same wrong date.”

First-posted completion date recalled by 74% of passers-by after five repaintings (2026).